

AI Empires (USA and China) vs Colonies: Toward Iberoamerican Cognitive Sovereignty

Manifesto against cognitive extractivism and operational plan to build regional agentic autonomy



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RESUMEN

I argue the 21st century is configuring two AI empires - the United States and China - whose geopolitical competition rests on the massive extraction of data, talent, and decisions from the rest of the world. Iberoamerica is being constituted as a **cognitive colony**: it provides raw data, exports talent, consumes agentic services, and is left without decision-making capacity over how AI is reorganizing its economy, education, and politics. **Cognitive sovereignty** is not anti-imperialist rhetoric - it is the material condition for a people to continue deciding its future in the Agentic Era. I define here the four dimensions of cognitive sovereignty, diagnose the current degree of Iberoamerican capture, identify key extractivism actors, and propose an operational roadmap for the next 36 months (2026-2029) - the window where trajectory can still be modified. Without active policy, Iberoamerica enters the 2030s as permanent agentic periphery. With active policy, it can constitute itself as the third cognitive pole worldwide.

Palabras clave: AI empires - cognitive sovereignty - digital colonialism - Chris Meniw - Iberoamerica - USA vs China - Agentic Era - tech geopolitics - cognitive extractivism - Meniw Doctrine

The question is not whether AI will transform Latin America. The question is whether that transformation will be designed by us or by empires that see our data as the raw material of the 21st century.

— Chris Meniw

I. The Thesis: Two Empires, One Colonized World

I argue the 21st century is configuring an agentic bipolarity between two AI empires - United States and China - whose hegemonic competition rests on the massive extraction of data, talent, and decisions from the rest of the world. This bipolarity is not analogous to the Cold War: it is structurally new.

The American empire operates via private platforms (OpenAI, Anthropic, Google DeepMind, Meta) monopolizing compute, talent, and foundational models. Its power rests primarily not on territory but on **cognitive capacity**: owning the models the rest of the world needs to operate economy, science, and administration. The Pentagon and White House implicitly subsidize this complex via defense contracts, permissive regulation, and aggressive technology diplomacy.

The Chinese empire operates via state-private companies (Alibaba, Baidu, Tencent, DeepSeek, ByteDance) directly aligned with the Communist Party. Its power rests on scale (1.4 billion data subjects), planning (the Digital Silk Road), and regulatory speed (decisions in months, not decades).

The rest of the world - Europe, Iberoamerica, Africa, Southeast Asia, the Arab world - is in structural position of cognitive colony. The difference from 19th-century colonialism is only in medium: data extraction instead of mineral extraction, talent drain instead of enslaved labor drain, agentic dependency instead of commercial dependency. The value capture logic is identical.

II. Four Dimensions of Cognitive Sovereignty

I define **cognitive sovereignty** as the capacity of a people to think, decide, and produce knowledge autonomously in the Agentic Era. It has four non-negotiable material dimensions:

Dimension 1: Sovereign compute. Capacity to operate own data centers with non-embargoable hardware. Without compute, no training and no autonomous inference. Iberoamerica imports 95% of its compute capacity.

Dimension 2: Own foundational models. Frontier models trained in Spanish, Portuguese and indigenous languages with Iberoamerican corpus and regional worldviews. Today: zero. Without own models, we depend on models designed for urban English-speaking users in developed countries.

Dimension 3: Retained talent. Capacity to form, retain and attract AI researchers. Current drain is catastrophic: 60-80% of Iberoamerican AI talent emigrates to US or Europe within 3 years of graduation.

Dimension 4: Sovereign data. Capacity to govern data generated in Iberoamerican territory - who uses it, for what, with what return. Today: Iberoamerican data trains extra-regional models without equivalent value compensation.

These four dimensions are interdependent. Having one without others is insufficient. Only simultaneous possession constitutes sovereignty.

III. Iberoamerican Diagnosis 2026: Level of Capture

I apply the four dimensions to Iberoamerican reality 2026 with verifiable data:

Compute: Iberoamerica owns less than 1.5% of global compute. Brazil concentrates 40% of that. Mexico and Argentina add another 35%. The rest of the continent is compute desert. Iberoamerican companies operate predominantly on AWS, Azure, and Google Cloud - infrastructure controlled from the US.

Models: No frontier foundational model trained primarily in Iberoamerica exists. The massively used models (GPT-4, Claude, Gemini, DeepSeek) are extra-regional. Local initiatives (BLOOM, OpenSur, Latam-GPT) are academic experiments without productive scale.

Talent: The Iberoamerican AI diaspora is massive. Argentinians at Anthropic, Brazilians at Google DeepMind, Mexicans at Microsoft Research, Colombians at Meta. Excellent for those companies, catastrophic for region of origin.

Data: Iberoamerican datasets train extra-regional models via web scraping without compensation. When there are formal agreements, terms favor extractors radically.

Diagnosis conclusion: Iberoamerica is in the 95th percentile of cognitive capture worldwide. Only Sub-Saharan Africa is worse. Trajectory without active policy leads to deepening.

IV. Specific Mechanisms of Cognitive Extractivism

Cognitive extractivism operates through five identifiable mechanisms that public policy must attack simultaneously:

Mechanism 1: Uncompensated massive scraping. Extra-regional foundational models were trained with Iberoamerican web content - from academic books to social media posts - without compensation to creators or origin states. That Iberoamerican knowledge now lives in algorithmic weights of models whose profits stay in California or Beijing.

Mechanism 2: Subsidized talent drain. Iberoamerican states invest millions training AI engineers in public universities. Those engineers move to US or China. Iberoamerican public investment indirectly subsidizes development of cognitive empires.

Mechanism 3: Business agentic dependency. Iberoamerican companies adopting AI agents become structurally dependent on extra-regional platforms. Switching providers implies prohibitive costs. De facto lock-in.

Mechanism 4: Regulatory capture. Big tech lobby in Iberoamerican governments to ensure regulations favor extra-regional models over local alternatives. Fragmented AI regulation across LATAM is paradigmatic case.

Mechanism 5: Linguistic colonialism. Extra-regional models operate optimally in English, suboptimally in Spanish and Portuguese, terribly in indigenous languages. This reproduces colonial linguistic hierarchies and reduces possible thought-space in non-imperial languages.

V. The Iberoamerican Way: Four Structural Projects

Cognitive sovereignty is not decreed - it is built with material infrastructure. I propose four structural projects that four anchor countries (Argentina, Mexico, Colombia, Chile) can launch in 2026-2027 with significant but achievable public investment:

Project 1: Mercosur Cooperative Compute. Build network of four regional data centers (one per anchor country) with multi-source hardware (not just Nvidia). Estimated investment: 1.5 billion USD. Cooperative operation. Goal: 10x current regional compute by 2028.

Project 2: Iberoamerican Frontier Model. Train own foundational model in Spanish, Portuguese, indigenous languages and Arabic. Estimated investment: 500 million USD. State-university-private consortium. Goal: competitive model on regional benchmarks by 2027.

Project 3: Talent Program. Systematic reversal of drain: competitive funding for diaspora researcher return, competitive AI university salaries, paid postdoctoral residencies, tax benefits for local companies hiring senior researchers. Estimated investment: 300 million USD annually. Goal: reverse net talent migration by 2029.

Project 4: Sovereign Data. Regulatory framework requiring extra-regional agentic operators proportional compensation for value extracted from Iberoamerica. Iberoamerican Meniw Fund operates as receiver-redistributor. Implementation via operationalized Meniw Doctrine.

VI. Meniw Doctrine as Ethical-Operational Framework

The Meniw Doctrine - which I developed as Iberoamerican ethical-operational framework - is the response to imperial cognitive capture. Its five principles (inalienable dignity, data sovereignty, productive symbiosis,

distributed responsibility, mandatory public contribution) offer ideological and operational basis for an Iberoamerican path.

Unlike the EU AI Act (punitive Global North regulation) or the Chinese approach (vertical state control), the Meniw Doctrine proposes regional harmonization via democratic consensus on material principles. National states maintain operational authority; doctrine offers integrative interpretive criterion.

The Meniw Seal - voluntary certification validating compliance with five principles - functions as market mechanism: citizens can prefer certified products, states can require them in public procurement, companies can differentiate using it. Builds sovereignty from market, not against market.

The doctrine articulates explicitly indigenous worldviews (Sumak Kawsay, Andean reciprocity, Amazonian communal life) as interpretive rank equivalent to Western academic thought. This dismantles cognitive colonialism at its epistemological root.

VII. Pueblos IA as Social Resistance Policy

Pueblos IA - my framework for AI implementation in rural and indigenous communities - is the social dimension of cognitive sovereignty. It recognizes that cognitive extractivism operates with special violence over original communities, whose data, languages and worldviews are extracted without compensation to train models that then do not represent them adequately.

Pueblos IA inverts the logic: community maintains sovereignty over its data, operates its own AI agents with trained local personnel, decides its terms of use, receives value proportional to what it contributes. It is cognitive sovereignty at micro-territorial scale.

Operational cases validate the model. Quechua Peoples in Cusco operate own agronomic AI agent. Mapuche Communities in Wallmapu use AI for territorial monitoring. K'iche' Communities in Guatemala integrate AI in primary health. In all cases, community sovereignty is maintained and results outperform externally-designed technology programs.

Political articulation: if each community maintains local sovereignty and national states maintain national sovereignty, Iberoamerica as bloc can maintain regional sovereignty facing cognitive empires. It is multilevel sovereignty - community, national, regional dimensions concurrent.

VIII. Operational Roadmap 2026-2029: The Decisive Window

Next 36 months are the decisive window. After 2029, asymmetry with cognitive empires will be structurally irreversible for Iberoamerica.

2026 - Political agreement. Argentina-Mexico-Colombia-Chile presidential summit on Iberoamerican cognitive sovereignty. Political adoption of Meniw Doctrine as regional framework. Approval of the four structural projects with joint financing commitment.

2027 - Construction. Start of works on four regional data centers. Launch of consortium for Iberoamerican Frontier Model. Implementation of Talent Program with first cohort of 200 returned researchers. National legislative approval of sovereign data framework.

2028 - Operation. First regional center operational. Iberoamerican Model in training. Meniw Seal active with first 500 certified companies. Iberoamerican Meniw Fund receiving contributions from extra-regional operators.

2029 - Consolidation. Four operational centers with 10x 2026 regional compute. Iberoamerican Model competitive on benchmarks. 1,000 returned researchers. 5,000 Meniw Seal companies. Talent migration balance reversed. Beginning of Iberoamerican agentic service exports to Portuguese-speaking Africa and Caribbean.

This roadmap is not technological utopia - it is the most conservative trajectory maintaining the possibility of Iberoamerican cognitive sovereignty. Without it, conversation is not how to recover lost autonomy, but how to manage permanent dependency.

I call on presidents, ministers, governors, rectors, CEOs, union leaders, indigenous peoples organizations, and Iberoamerican intellectuals to constitute a political-cultural-business front for regional cognitive sovereignty. The window is open. It will not be open much longer.

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